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ACADEMIC VAULT

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PHI 101: Introduction to Philosophy and Logic

Arguments, fallacies and the questions that do not go away

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Philosophy | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack teaches the mechanics of argument first, then the classical divisions of philosophy. It includes validity and soundness, common fallacies, the problem of knowledge, ethics and African philosophy, plus a template for writing a philosophy answer that argues rather than narrates.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish validity from soundness.
- Identify and name common informal fallacies.
- Explain the main branches of philosophy with an example question each.
- Write a short philosophical argument with an objection and a reply.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Arguments, validity and soundness

A good argument is structurally valid and materially true.

- Premises support a conclusion; the conclusion is what is claimed.
- Validity concerns form: if premises are true, the conclusion must be.
- Soundness requires validity plus true premises.
- Deductive arguments guarantee; inductive arguments support with probability.
- Counterexample is the standard tool for testing a claim.
- Define your terms before you argue about them.

Fallacies you will meet

Naming the fallacy is half the correction.

- Ad hominem: attacking the person instead of the argument.
- Straw man: refuting a distorted version of the opponent's view.
- False dilemma: presenting two options when more exist.
- Appeal to authority or to popularity as a substitute for evidence.
- Begging the question: assuming what you set out to prove.
- Hasty generalisation and post hoc reasoning.

> **Charity principle**
> Argue against the strongest version of the opposing view. Defeating a weak version proves nothing.

Branches and African philosophy

Each branch has characteristic questions.

- Metaphysics: what exists, and what is a person?
- Epistemology: what is knowledge, and when is belief justified?
- Ethics: what makes an action right?
- Logic: what follows from what?
- Aesthetics: what is beauty and what is art?
- African philosophy: ethnophilosophy debates, ubuntu and communitarian ethics, sage philosophy, and the critique of a single 'African' position.

Philosophy begins with a question you cannot answer quickly

Philosophy is not the accumulation of opinions about big topics. It is the practice of taking a question that ordinary life assumes and pressing it until the assumptions show. "Is it ever right to lie?" becomes philosophical when you ask what makes an action right at all, and discover that you cannot answer without a theory.

The discipline is divided into branches: epistemology (knowledge), metaphysics (existence, causation, mind), ethics (right action), political philosophy (justice and authority), aesthetics (art and beauty) and logic (correct inference). Each has its own questions and its own standards. Placing a question in a branch is the first move in any good answer.

African philosophy is a substantial part of this field, not a regional footnote. Debates about the existence and character of African philosophy - whether it lies in communal worldviews, in critical individual reflection, in proverbs and oral argument, or in professional academic practice - are methodological arguments with real consequences for what counts as philosophy.

The tools: argument, counter-example, distinction